THE FORENSICS WAY

ISSUE 07 | FORENSICS AWARENESS THIS WEEK | TUESDAY, MARCH 17, 2026

FRONT PAGE

INSIDER THREAT

The Trusted Responder: US Prosecutors Allege IR Consultant Aided BlackCat Ransomware Actors

In one of the most disturbing insider threat cases in recent DFIR history, US prosecutors have alleged that a licensed incident response consultant deliberately assisted **BlackCat/ALPHV ransomware operators** during live attack negotiations and intrusion operations — converting a trusted remediation role into an active criminal partnership. The consultant reportedly exploited privileged network access granted during incident response engagements to facilitate attacker persistence and hamper victim recovery.

The case carries profound implications for the entire IR industry. Vendor vetting, privileged access governance, and independent verification of remediation steps are no longer optional diligence — they are evidentiary necessities. Forensic examiners responding to ransomware incidents should now treat all third-party IR consultants as potential privileged-access risks and document every action taken under external access credentials.

LIVING-OFF-THE-LAND ATTACK

Stryker Breach: Attackers Abuse Microsoft Intune to Disrupt Medical Device Supply Chain

A sophisticated intrusion at **Stryker**, one of the world's largest medical device manufacturers, disrupted manufacturing and shipping operations after attackers abused **Microsoft Intune** and other native management tools rather than deploying conventional malware. By operating entirely within legitimate IT management infrastructure, the threat actors evaded every malware-centric control in the environment — a textbook living-off-the-land execution.

The forensic challenge presented by Intune-based attacks is severe: because no malicious binaries touch disk, traditional IOC-based detection is blind. Investigators must reconstruct attacker actions from Intune audit logs, Azure AD sign-in records, and device compliance policy change histories. The Stryker case is an urgent reminder that management plane forensics is now a core IR competency, not an edge case.

Threat Bulletin

ACTIVE EXPLOIT

CVE-2026-3910

Chromium V8 Engine — Type Confusion vulnerability enabling remote code execution via malicious web content. Actively exploited in the wild and added to CISA's KEV catalog March 13. Emergency Chrome 146 patch released.

Forensic Note: Preserve browser profiles and V8 crash telemetry; exploitation leaves renderer process anomalies in crash logs.

CRITICAL

CVE-2026-26110

Microsoft Office Remote Code Execution via Preview Pane. An attacker can execute code on a target machine without the victim opening a file — previewing the attachment in Explorer is sufficient. One of two zero-days in March Patch Tuesday's 84-fix release. *Forensic Note:* Check Outlook preview events in Windows telemetry alongside the standard file-open artifact chain.

MALWARE SPOTLIGHT

Avrecon Botnet (SocksEscort)

US and European authorities dismantled the SocksEscort proxy-for-hire service powered by the Avrecon botnet — 360,000 compromised routers recruited since 2020. Used extensively to launder ransomware C2 traffic and fraud operations. *Forensic Note:* Router compromise leaves minimal on-device artifacts; hunt via outbound connection anomalies and firmware integrity checks.

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HISTORICAL ARCHIVES | HISTORY OF DIGITAL INVESTIGATION | TUESDAY, MARCH 17, 2026

CASE STUDIES: HISTORICAL GRID

OPM DATA BREACH (2014–2015)

21.5 Million Fingerprints — The Worst Espionage Breach in US History

Chinese state actors exfiltrated the complete security clearance files — including fingerprints, personal histories, and foreign contacts — of 21.5 million federal employees and contractors from the Office of Personnel Management. The breach went undetected for over a year. Forensic investigators found the attackers had used stolen credentials from an OPM contractor as their initial access vector, establishing a direct line between third-party vendor risk and catastrophic data loss.

TARGET POS BREACH (2013)

40 Million Cards Stolen Through an HVAC Vendor

Attackers stole 40 million credit and debit card numbers from Target's point-of-sale systems by first compromising Fazio Mechanical, a small HVAC contractor with remote network access. The case pioneered retail DFIR methodology, introduced RAM scraping malware to mainstream incident response, and remains the definitive case study in third-party supply chain risk — directly applicable to this week's Stryker Intune intrusion.

STUXNET / OPERATION OLYMPIC GAMES (2010)

The First Cyberweapon Deployed Against Iran

Jointly developed by the NSA and Israel's Unit 8200, Stuxnet was a precision instrument designed to destroy Iranian centrifuges at Natanz while reporting normal status to operators. Its forensic discovery by Kaspersky and Symantec researchers established the foundational methodology for ICS/SCADA malware analysis still applied today.

NOTPETYA WIPER ATTACK (2017)

The $10 Billion Lesson in Destructive Malware

Disguised as ransomware, Russia's NotPetya was a pure wiper that caused an estimated $10 billion in global damages. Forensic analysts at ESET and Kaspersky determined the ransom facade was deliberate misdirection — a lesson that directly informs how investigators must approach Iran-aligned BaqiyatLock and Sicarii deployments today.

TOOLS OF THE TRADE

UTILITY / SCRIPT

DeepBlueCLI

OPEN SOURCE — ERIC CONRAD

PowerShell-based Windows Event Log analysis tool built specifically to hunt living-off-the-land attacks. Detects suspicious PowerShell usage, pass-the-hash, Mimikatz activity, and user creation events — exactly the artifact chain left behind by Intune-based intrusions like the Stryker breach.

OPEN SOURCE

Autopsy

V4.21 — 2026

The most widely used open-source digital forensics platform. Version 4.21 adds improved ML-based file classifier modules, enhanced timeline analysis, and expanded support for newer Android filesystem structures — a reliable foundation for examiners at every level.

OPEN SOURCE

Wireshark

V4.4 — 2026

The gold standard for network protocol analysis. v4.4 adds improved decryption support for TLS 1.3 sessions when keys are available, enhanced packet filtering, and new dissectors for cloud-native protocols. Essential for tracing Avrecon-style botnet C2 traffic buried inside legitimate service flows.

COMMERCIAL

Semperis ADFR

ACTIVE DIRECTORY FOREST RECOVERY

Purpose-built for Active Directory forensics and recovery following ransomware attacks. Captures a forensic snapshot of AD state pre-encryption, supports tiered forest recovery, and generates change-diff reports that serve as primary evidence in post-incident investigations involving credential-based lateral movement.

PRIORITY CVE ADVISORIES

ARCHIVE ALERT

CVE-2026-0145 (PALO ALTO)

PAN-OS GlobalProtect authentication bypass. Preferred initial-access vector for Iranian APT groups Seedworm and APT42. *Forensic Note:* Audit GlobalProtect session logs for anomalous authentication patterns.

ARCHIVE ALERT

CVE-2026-1834 (FORTINET)

FortiGate SSL-VPN unauthenticated RCE. Actively weaponized by Iran-aligned actors as a secondary access mechanism. *Forensic Note:* Review SSL-VPN session initiations and anomalous HTTPD child processes.

RECENT MALWARE WATCH

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BAQIYATLOCK WIPER

Iran-aligned wiper deployed as a ransomware facade — no decryption key ever issued. Targets MBR and file headers for permanent destruction. Volatile memory capture is the only viable forensic path post-execution.

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WEZRAT (APT42)

Iran's APT42 infostealer persisting via legitimate cloud services to harvest credentials and session tokens. Minimal system footprint — hunt via cloud auth logs and anomalous OAuth token grants.